Modi in person as well as to people in America,' Obama declared. 'For a country like India where there is a Muslim population that is successful, integrated and considers itself as Indian, which is not the case in some other countries, this should be nourished and cultivated.'

Obama's message on both occasions was pointed: if India did not resolve the problems of bigotry that are dividing the country, Mr Modi's proclaimed ambitious development plans would be thwarted. It was a message many of us in the political Opposition had also been giving Mr Modi and his colleagues. But coming from a US president, whose visit was being hailed by the government as a diplomatic triumph and whose 'bromance' with the Indian PM had seen first names being used and much friendly banter, it was a pointed reminder of the fundamental contradiction at the heart of Modi's regime.

As I had spelt out in my 2014 book *India Shastra*, Mr Modi's speeches and rhetoric appeared to recognise, and harness, a vital shift in our national politics from a politics of identity to a politics of performance; yet he had risen to power at the helm of a party, the BJP, which is ill-suited to the challenge of delinking India's polity from the incendiary issue of religious identity on which it had built its base.

Of course, Indians don't need an American visitor to tell them to uphold the ideal of freedom of religion, when our history is one of coexistence, the acceptance of religious diversity is deeply embedded in our culture and our Constitution reflects our pluralism. It's a great pity that a foreign leader is obliged to recognise that some Indians do not share the values on which India is built and which are reified in our Constitution. As I have long argued, Indian democracy is all about the management of diversity, and if we don't respect our diversity we will no longer be the India that Mahatma Gandhi fought to free.

But for the first time, India has elected a prime minister who was himself named for 'severe violations of religious freedom' in reports by the US State Department from 2002 onwards, refused an American visa and was banned from entering the United States before he became prime minister. Mr Modi wasn't elected PM for condoning violence against minorities, but to fulfil an aspirational development vision he effectively articulated. Mr Obama's speech was a way of telling him he can't do